

"The digital age is a cultural revolution."

Interview with Agostino Ghiglia

Agostino Ghiglia, author of "Digital Civic Education - Essential ABC" (Maggioli publisher), explains to us why it is essential to acquire digital awareness.

Interview with Agostino Ghiglia, member of the Authority for the Protection of Personal Data (by Francesca Galici, "Il Giornale", August 2, 2023)

Our world is no longer just the tangible one of reality but also the virtual one, where we spend increasing amounts of time, often without adequate awareness. It is precisely to understand, to learn how to live in this world, where there exists our alter ego, a digital twin, that "Digital Civic Education - Essential ABC" (Maggioli publisher) is born, a book written by Agostino Ghiglia, a member of the board of the Authority for the Protection of Personal Data and former parliamentarian.

We reach him by phone to discuss the objectives and ambitions of this volume, an indispensable guide to navigating the complicated virtual world, especially understanding its fundamental elements, the basics, starting from language: "It should not be considered a topic. The digital age is not a sector; it is a cultural revolution that permeates all aspects of our lives. We must live it as a new reality to be approached with increasing awareness."

The goal, Ghiglia explains, is "to spread digital civic education, starting from the assumption that the digital age is not a simple evolution of the internet but a new discovery of fire, an epochal revolution that must be accompanied. Unfortunately, we have the belief that new generations, starting from digital natives, are aware and conscious of what lies behind simply because they were born with a phone in hand." Therefore, Ghiglia continues, if civic education imparted to those born until the 1980s served to provide the basic rules for life, in the digital age, young people need to receive digital civic education to "explain to them the rules of this new world that is taking shape." For this reason, according to the author, this should be a mandatory subject in schools from the first cycle, to guide the very young towards understanding a world that will come but, in part, already exists.

A first step in this direction is the understanding of language and the words that constitute it: "The book also includes a glossary, an ABC, like that of Pinocchio, to build the foundation from the simplest elements that are too often taken for granted but whose meanings are not even known." Lacking the basics, one exposes oneself to "enormous" risks in the digital world, as Ghiglia explains, especially in the area of data protection: "Going online without awareness means disseminating data everywhere and completely losing control, without knowing how it will be used. The risk is that it may be used against us."

The author of the book gives the example of "sharenting," a neologism that identifies the practice of parents sharing photos of their children online: "These photos, removed from context and repurposed, perhaps years later, can be used in illegal activities such as child pornography or biometric recognition for a bank account. And this is just one example."

For this reason, Ghiglia warns in his book about the necessity of providing the same protection to the physical person and their "digital twin." Simply opening a weather app or a social media platform in the morning to check the news not only allows us to acquire information but also transmits our data. "This digital twin will feed databases and profiles, geolocations, and therefore we must take great care and attention for it, especially for it, especially with a future perspective," Ghiglia continues. This is a fundamental concept to learn, especially for new generations, who know very little about this world. "Digital natives, simply because they were born with devices, know how to use them very well but do not know what is behind them and often do not understand the meaning of the terms that drive the digital world, all Anglo-Saxon, that define the new digital era," the author continues, emphasizing the importance of being able to navigate a jungle of neologisms that are used but not deeply understood.

For this reason, the author wanted to address both today's parents and, above all, the very young users of the digital world: "It is not a scientific treatise. Its goal is to try to spread the ABC of the digital age. Quoting my high school physics teacher, I like to say that 'one must learn the simple things well,' which are the foundations of life. And that is why it is aimed at those who want to understand and

know, at those who feel 'ignorant' because they are unaware of that particular world and want to learn starting from simple things." The topic, addressed in its entirety, is enormous, but Ghiglia aims to provide the framework of knowledge, the foundations, and the skeleton to then build the skyscraper of awareness.